



RESURGENCE MEETS REALITY CHECK

A **resilient campaign** ends in bronze, but familiar concerns remain, especially surrounding squad depth.

Nihit Sachdeva

nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

After not winning any medals in the first 31 editions of the Thomas Cup, India has now finished on the podium twice in the last four years. The collection, which started with a historic gold in Bangkok in 2022, now also features a bronze in Horsens, Denmark.

Placed in Group A with defending champion China, Canada and Australia, qualifying for the quarterfinals wasn't a difficult task for India as it beat the latter two 4-1 and 5-0. Against China, in the battle to decide the group topper, the team narrowly lost 2-3.

For the knockout stage, India was drawn to face Chinese Taipei in the quarterfinals. Lakshya Sen (**left**) provided the ideal start, saving two match points in his thrilling 18-21, 22-20, 21-17 triumph over World No. 6 Chou Tien Chen. The premier doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty overcame a stiff challenge from Hsian Chieh Chiu and Wang Chi-lin for a 23-21, 19-21, 21-12 victory. While All England Open champion and World No. 10 Lin Chun-yi did have some physical limitations, it required tournament debutant Ayush Shetty (**facing page, below**) to produce his best performance of the tournament for a 21-16, 21-17 win, clinching the tie 3-0 for India.

Winning a Thomas Cup medal is no mean feat. It requires squad depth — multiple high-quality options for singles and at least one solid doubles duo, if not two. India's squad retained the core from the team that stunned 14-time champion Indonesia in the final four years ago — Lakshya, Kidambi Srikanth, H. S. Prannoy and the Satwik-Chirag pair. A rising star in World No. 18 Ayush and an improving doubles specialist in Hariharan Amsakarunan brought freshness and new energy.

There were hopes of emulating the 2022 miracle. However, in the semifinals, India faced a high-spirited French side that had earlier upset Indonesia 4-1 in their final group match and Japan 3-0 in the quarterfinals.